

of computer hardware and networking and developed my troubleshooting skills, which led me to believe that systems administration was the ideal job for me. From the job security perspective, I have always felt that the sysadmin is the last person to leave the firm," says Phatak.

So, why have Linux sysadmin skills suddenly got hot in the Indian recruitment landscape? Some experts say the growing adoption of open source software across varied sectors is one of the major reasons for this increasing demand. "Regardless of the economic situation and the state of the job market, right from desktop support and server support to network management and IT security management, a sysadmin's skills are in great demand all over the world. Talking about India, Linux administrators are in high demand because of Linux's increasing installation base, and they are expected to know a bit of network designing and cyber security too," quips Phatak.

The mushrooming of e-commerce portals is seen as yet another reason for the rising demand for proficient Linux administrators. Sharma comes up with an interesting example. "Most of the e-commerce portals are based on the LAMP stack and as the market grows in India, so does the demand for Linux administrators. The open source market is growing and Linux has turned out to be the most successful operating system. Adventurous developers seeking some freely available code from any part of the world and customising it as per their requirements, to build some successful application, is the order of the day. This needs huge server-side configurations and customisation, and can be successfully achieved only with open source operating systems, which support multi-tasking, multi-threading and multi-processing to handle large volumes of end-user requests. The role of a sysadmin is very important here," explains Sharma.

Varad Gupta, CTO and founder of Delhi-based Keen and Able Computers (K&A), a leading Indian open source solutions provider, feels that the job of a Linux sysadmin is no less than a CEO of a company. "You should have troubleshooting skills, and you should have the temperament and patience to ensure that the whole system is managed effectively. It is important to have the willingness to learn on a continuous basis if you wish to climb the ladder of success," he says.

At a time when Linux systems administrators are much in demand, what skills do hiring managers look for while recruiting them? "Managers primarily look for daily administration such as server maintenance, network maintenance, etc. Some managers also expect sysadmin teams to go a step forward and work on network designing, scripting and security. In general, a good IT manager expects the sysadmin team to have automation experts who can automate trivial and time-consuming daily sysadmin jobs, and utilise the saved time in improving the reliability and security of the firm's IT infrastructure. Hiring managers typically look for good analytical and problem-solving skills, which are vital for sysadmin jobs. Besides this, the

willingness to learn automation, create sensible technical reports and the desire to work late hours are aspects on which a candidate is judged too," opines Phatak.

Sharma elaborates on this point with reference to freshers versus those who are armed with experience. "If you are a fresher, you must at least be an RHCE and your basic concepts should be strong. You should be able to meet the organisation's requirements. And if you have the experience, you should be a RHCE and RHCS, with certification on MySQL/Oracle, the cloud, storage, clusters and CCNA. You need to be technically and analytically strong and have a sharp vision, a positive attitude and confidence," says Sharma.

Experts say that Linux sysadmins have an advantage over their Windows counterparts. "The Linux base is increasing in India practically every year, as more and more firms are shifting to open source implementations. Reduced installation costs are helping this migration. While Windows knowledge is still a must for sysadmins even today, a person knowing Windows and Linux is given preference when it comes to jobs," says Phatak.

What does this demand mean in terms of remuneration? "It is a myth that a sysadmin is not highly paid. In fact, it is usually found that sysadmins are treated as important company assets who are not easily replaceable, which prompts the employer to provide remuneration that is the best in the industry. Firms also invest in training them," says Phatak.

So, do certifications matter, and do they boost one's employability?

Experts feel that certifications are important especially when it comes to testing a candidate's knowledge about the operating systems and networking concepts. "A few vendor-specific certifications such as MCP, CCNA, CCNP, etc, are important too, because these can help hiring managers get the candidates on board, and eventually lead them on to the cyber security administration track," adds Phatak.

And what are the hot keywords you should put in your resume to grab the recruiter's attention? "Just show what you specialise in. You are searched for on the basis of your technical skills. So be specific and clear about your profile while building it," quips Sharma.

"Recommended hot keywords would typically be the various flavours of the Linux operating systems that the candidate has hands-on knowledge about. Besides that, various tools in the area of network monitoring, server maintenance and backup maintenance are seen in resumes too. Lately, the sysadmin function is merging into cyber security administration; hence, keywords such as vulnerability assessment, penetration testing, etc, will help, provided those skill sets have actually been acquired," shares Phatak. 

By Priyanka Sarkar

The author is a member of the editorial team. She loves to weave in and out the little nuances of life and scribble her thoughts and experiences in her personal blog.